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Gen Con Diary Day 2

By John Clark
Special Projects Editor

The crowd waiting to get in the doors to the exhibit hall.

Chris Bradley, of Columbus, tries one of the console game replicas from DreamAuthentics of Indianapolis.

My better judgment of Wednesday evening faded away by Thursday morning and my son and I found ourselves swimming upstream against the salmon flow that is the 10 a.m. first-day rush into the Gen Con exhibit hall. More than 200 dealers are on hand at the show, which runs through Sunday in Indianapolis at the Indiana Convention Center, waiting to sell eager gamers the newest games, gadgets and gizmos.

Thousands and thousands of gamers camp out in front of these doors, waiting for a chance to snag free dice or to buy the long-awaited sequel or accessory for their game of choice.

I vowed yesterday not to fight the rush, because no amount of free swag is worth getting stampeded by the mob. But I foolishly decided to run an errand near the exhibit hall doors and the crush of humanity was overwhelming. There are so many odd and interesting people, in so many fascinating T-shirts and costumes that it was possible for a young woman wearing a chain mail bikini and painted in orange with tiger stripes and a tail to pass by us, without meriting even a mention. Elves and wizards and Capt. Jack Sparrow all passed through the crowd, jostling, bustling and jockeying like the more mundane gamers.

Even with the press of humanity, once the doors opened the crowd moved quickly to rake in its loot and within a few moments we were able to reach the Upper Deck booth. Upper Deck is best known for its "Yu-Gi-Oh!" and "Vs." trading card games but my 9-year-old desperately wanted to learn to play "Avatar."

The goal of "Avatar" is to land three card attacks against your opponent, using the cards in your deck to jab and parry back and forth. As you continue to work your way through your deck you build in power and energy reserves until you can launch a devastating special attack hidden within the thicker-than-normal body of your main character's card.

The game moved quickly, even though our attention was continually drawn away by new, bright, shiny things to see as they passed by carried, waved and worn by the crowd.

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Later in the afternoon, we returned to the Upper Deck booth for a sneak preview of the new "World of Warcraft" trading card game and an interview with the game's line developer. I'm planning on writing a full review when the game is available in October, but we saw enough to note that the feel of the game is much like the massive multi-player online role-playing game on which it is based. Place names, weapons and the Alliance and Horde factions will seem awfully familiar to computer gamers.

One of my last stops before leaving the exhibit hall for the day was the DreamAuthentics booth. The Indianapolis-based company has recreated the stand-up arcade behemonth of my teen years, packaging hundreds of computer game remakes in a button-masher's dream console. Almost 200 games come preloaded on the system, which at its heart is a standard home computer. But the keyboard has been rewired to the buttons, joysticks and controls on the top of the console. And the standard sized monitor has been replaced by a 27-inch or 32-inch crystal clear unit which makes those old games look really sharp. Since this is really a PC inside, all other PC games will play on this system, so you aren't limited to the old-school favorites.

Connections can even be built in that allow a PlayStation2 or Xbox game system to be plugged into the console and hidden behind the "coin drop" door built into the front of the case. To rouse passerby's interest, one of the demonstration models at the show featured a playable version of "Guitar Hero" for the crowd.

The console case is customizable and can feature company logos or slogans, rather than the standard manufacturer boilerplate. But all this retro fun does not come cheap. The DreamAuthentics systems run into the thousands of dollars, with a Gen Con special carrying a price tag of about $2,995.

After the convention center began winding down for the night, my friends and I jumped into "Lunch Money," a card game that simulates a playground beat-down, complete with taunts, grating rhymes and disturbing levels of violence. The game is meant for adults, despite the child-centered background, and the play encourages players to think of new, graphic and amusing descriptions for the violence their cards are dealing and receiving.

The game, from Atlas Games, is quick, brutal and an awful lot of fun.

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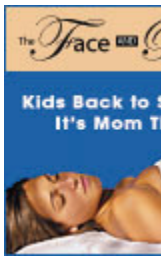

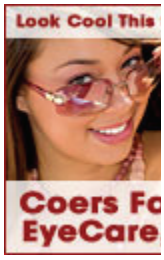

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